

Same Sex Sexual Activity

prc-same-sex-sexual-activity

Marriage & Sexuality · Sexual Ethics · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide

directness direct

variants stable

Statement under examination

Same-sex sexual activity is sin, contrary to creation design and the consistent witness of Scripture.

In plain language

Scripture uses the same negative valuation for same-sex sexual acts from the Torah through the letters of Paul, in vocabulary the texts themselves bind together. Leviticus 18:22 forbids a male (zakar, H2145) to lie the lyings of a woman (mishkav, H4904, plus ishshah, H0802) with another male and calls the act an abomination (toebah, H8441). Leviticus 20:13 repeats the identical cluster and attaches a death sanction, so the valuation is fixed, not isolated. In Romans 1:26-27 Paul writes that females (thelys, G2338) exchanged the natural use (phusike chresis, G5446 plus G5540, meaning the ordinary God-given sexual use) for what is against nature (para physin, G5449, meaning contrary to created order), and males (arsen, G730) leaving the natural use of the female burned in desire for one another, males with males working shamelessness (aschemosune, G808, a shameful indecent act) and receiving recompense (antimisthia, G489, due payback). His chosen words for male and female are arsen and thelys, the same pair that Genesis 1:27 in the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) uses for the creational binary, which is what against nature is set against. In 1 Corinthians 6:9 and 1 Timothy 1:10 Paul lists male-bedders (arsenokoitai, G733) among those who will not inherit the kingdom and among acts contrary to sound teaching. This compound word is built from arsen (male) plus koite (bed, sexual lying), the very two words that stand side by side in the Greek of Leviticus 18:22 (meta arsenos ou koimethese koiten gynaikos, meaning with a male you shall not lie a woman's lying). That word-formation lexically carries the Torah prohibition into the New Testament letters. Why do readers diverge? Three real verbal pressure points exist. First, malakos (G3120, soft) is a broad word that can mean soft clothing elsewhere, so some narrow its scope here. Second, against nature (para physin) can in some contexts mean cultural convention, so some read it that way. Third, abomination (toebah) is sometimes argued to be a ritual category. Each touches scope or background but none reverses the valuation, because the act is defined by the sex of the partner in every passage, the reciprocal phrase toward one another (eis allelous) makes the Romans participants symmetric, and the kingdom and sound-teaching clauses fix the judgment. Across law and epistle the verbal pattern speaks with one voice.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0802	אִשָּׁה	ishshah	woman	781
H2145	זָכָר	zakar	male	82
H4904	מִשְׁכָּב	mishkav	bed	46
H7901	שָׁכַב	shakav	to lie down	213
H8441	תּוֹעֵבָה	toebah	abomination	117

G0240	ἀλλήλων	allēlōn	one another	
G0268	ἁμαρτωλοῖς	hamartōlos	sinful	
G0459	ἄνομος	anomos	lawless	11
G0489	ἀντιμισθία	antimisthia	recompense	2
G0730	ἄρσεν	arsen	male	9
G0733	ἄρσενοκοίτης	arsenokoites	sodomite	2
G0765	ἄσεβέσι	asebēs	ungodly	
G0808	ἀσχημοσύνη	aschemosune	indecent	2
G0932	βασιλεία	basileia	kingdom	165
G1319	διδασκαλία	didaskalia	teaching	
G2338	θῆλυς	thelys	female	5
G2816	κληρονομέω	kleronomeo	to inherit	18
G3120	μαλακός	malakos	soft/effeminate	4
G4205	πόρνος	pornos	sexual sinner	11
G5446	φυσικός	phusikos	natural	3
G5449	φύσις	physis	nature	14
G5540	χρῆσις	chresis	use	2

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The word-pattern in the original languages is dense, spread across the whole Bible (pan-canonical), and uniform in how it judges the act. Leviticus 18:22 prohibits a male (zakar, H2145) from lying with what it calls the lyings of a woman (mishkebei ishshah, H4904 plus H0802, meaning the kind of sexual lying that belongs with a woman) and labels it an abomination (toebah, H8441), a verdict repeated in Leviticus 20:13 with the death penalty attached. Romans 1:26-27 frames the act with the phrase natural use (phusike chresis, G5446 plus G5540) and against nature (para physin, G3844 plus G5449, meaning contrary to the created order), tying nature (physis) to the male and female pair, then names males with males (arsenes en arsesin, G0730) working shamelessness (aschemosune, G0808, a shameful, indecent act). 1 Corinthians 6:9 and 1 Timothy 1:10 use the word arsenokoites (G0733), a compound word built from the two stems arsen (male) plus koite (bed, sexual lying), the same two stems that stand side by side in the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint (LXX) of Leviticus 18:22, so the New Testament term lexically encodes the Torah prohibition in its very letters. Every occurrence of these terms in the Bible assigns a negative valuation. The creational ground (Genesis 1:27 in the Septuagint uses the same arsen (male) and thelys (female) pair) anchors the against-nature (para physin) reasoning in the words themselves.

Scripture

Gen.1.27 · for · genre: narrative · figures: merism

Key terms. G0730 ἄρσεν, G2338 θήλυς

Force. The Hebrew pair male (zakar) plus female (neqebah), rendered male and female (arsen kai thely) in the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint (LXX), establishes the male and female creational binary as the positive ground that the later prohibition vocabulary presupposes. Paul's choice of male (arsen) and female (thelys) (rather than the more common adult-male word aner and adult-woman word gyne) in Romans 1:26-27 reuses precisely this creational pair, so the verbal link between creation and the against-nature (para physin, meaning contrary to created order) clause is in the word selection itself.

Lev.18.22 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H2145 זָכָר, H7901 שָׁכַב, H4904 מְשַׁכְּבִים, H0802 אִשָּׁה, H8441 תְּנוּעָה

Force. The negated prohibition you shall not lie (lo tishkav, tagged HVqi2ms, which is a second-person masculine singular Qal imperfect, meaning the simple active form of the Hebrew verb in an ongoing or repeated past or general aspect, here functioning as a direct command) takes male (zakar) as its direct object, marked by the Hebrew object marker et, and is qualified by the lyings of a woman (mishkebei ishshah, the masculine plural construct of bed or lying (mishkav) plus the absolute woman (ishshah)). The predicate it is abomination (toebah hi) closes the clause as a predicate plus predicate-complement verdict in the ETCBC clause structure (a published Hebrew syntactic database). The act is defined purely by the sex of the partner with no cultic (religious-ritual), coercive, or age qualifier in the syntax.

Lev.20.13 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H2145 זָכָר, H7901 שָׁכַב, H4904 מְשַׁכְּבִים, H8441 תְּנוּעָה

Force. An apodictic (unconditional, you-shall-not-style) restatement using the identical cluster male (zakar) plus lying (mishkav) plus abomination (toebah) from Leviticus 18:22, now with the consequence-clause they shall surely be put to death (mot yumetu) attaching the highest legal sanction to both parties. The repetition of the same word-roots fixes the valuation rather than leaving it isolated to a single clause.

Rom.1.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2338 θήλειαι, G5446 φυσικός, G5540 χρήσις, G5449 φύσις

Force. The female (thelys) subjects (plural feminine nominative, meaning the subject form of the noun) exchanged (metellaxan, aorist active indicative third plural, meaning a completed past action in straightforward statement form done by them) the natural use (phusike chresis) into that which is against nature (eis ten para physin, meaning into the use contrary to created order). The aorist (a completed past action) plus the against-nature (para physin) prepositional phrase frames the act as a deliberate deviation from a prior natural pattern. The verse is the first half of a paired male and female structure that the next verse completes.

Rom.1.27 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0730 ἄρσενες, G5446 φυσικός, G5540 χρήσις, G0240 ἀλλήλων, G0808 ἀσχημοσύνη, G0489 ἀντιμισθία

Force. The males (arsenes) likewise (homoios) having left (aphentes, aorist active participle, meaning a completed past action expressed as a participle) the natural use of the female (ten phusiken chresin tes theleias) were inflamed in their desire toward one another (exekauthesan en te orexei auton eis allelous), males in males working out the shameless act (arsenes en arsesin ten aschemosunen katergazomenoi), and receiving the recompense (kai ten antimisthian apolambanontes, meaning the due payback). The explicit clause males in males (arsenes en arsesin) names same-sex male activity in the words themselves, and shamelessness (aschemosune) and recompense (antimisthia) carry the negative valuation in the grammar. The verse forecloses a reading limited to prostitution-only or pederasty-only (the older-man-and-boy pattern) because the reciprocal phrase toward one another (eis allelous) makes the participants symmetric, not asymmetric.

1Cor.6.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0733 ἀρσενοκοῖται, G3120 μαλακοί, G4205 πόρνοι, G0932 βασιλείαν, G2816 κληρονομήσουσιν

Force. A vice catalogue (list of condemned behaviors) governed by they will not inherit (ou kleronomesousin, future active indicative third plural, meaning a future simple statement of fact) plus kingdom of God (basileian theou). The list places the soft ones (malakoi, G3120, soft, here in a sexual sense meaning the sexually passive partner, per the standard Greek-English lexicon Louw-Nida entry 88.281) and male-bedders (arsenokoitai, G0733, those who bed males) adjacent to the sexually immoral (pornoi) and adulterers (moichoi). The compound male-bedder (arsenokoites) is morphologically (in its word-formation) built from male (arsen) plus bed or sexual lying (koite), the exact two stems standing side by side in the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint (LXX), of Leviticus 18:22 (with a male you shall not lie a woman's lying, meta arsenos ou koimethese koiten gynaikos). That word-formation makes the catalogue a deliberate verbal pointer back to the Levitical prohibition.

1Cor.6.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0932 βασιλείαν, G2816 κληρονομήσουσιν

Force. The catalogue continues with thieves (kleptai), the greedy (pleonektai), drunkards (methusoi), revilers (loidoroi), and swindlers (harpages), then repeats kingdom of God they will not inherit (basileian theou ou kleronomesousin). The second occurrence of will not inherit (kleronomesousin) closes the inclusio (a literary bracket where a section opens and closes with the same words) around the list begun in verse 9, so male-bedders (arsenokoitai) is enclosed in a clause whose verb explicitly denies kingdom inheritance to the named categories.

1Tim.1.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0459 ἀνόμοις, G0268 ἁμαρτωλοῖς, G0765 ἀσεβέσι

Force. The law is laid down not for a righteous person (ou dikaios) but for the lawless (anomois) plus the insubordinate (anupotaktos), the impious (asebesi) plus sinners (hamartolois), the unholy (anosiois) plus the profane (bebelois). This frames verse 10: the following vice list is explicitly characterized as conduct the law condemns, not as morally indifferent behavior.

1Tim.1.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4205 πόρνοις, G0733 ἀρσενοκοῖταις, G1319 διδασκαλία

Force. The list names the sexually immoral (pornois), male-bedders (arsenokoitais, G0733), and slave-traders (andrapodistais) among acts opposed to (antikeitai) the sound teaching (te hygiainouse didaskalia). The same compound male-bedder (arsenokoites) from 1 Corinthians 6:9 reappears, again opposed to sound doctrine, confirming the term as a fixed verbal marker for the condemned act rather than a one-off coinage. The adjacency to slave-traders (andrapodistais) shows Paul knows the vocabulary for trafficker exploitation and uses a distinct word for the act itself.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Lev.18.22	Lev.20.13	tsk	1
1Cor.6.9	Lev.18.22	tsk	1
1Tim.1.10	Lev.18.22	tsk	1
Rom.1.27	Gen.1.27	openbible	1
1Cor.6.9	Gen.19.5	tsk	1
1Tim.1.10	Gen.19.5	tsk	1
Rom.1.26	Gen.19.5	tsk	1
1Tim.1.10	Exod.20.7	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.6.9 · addressed

The term soft (malakos, G3120) carries a broader semantic range (soft, delicate of clothing in Matthew 11:8 and Luke 7:25; effeminate or sexually passive in the 1 Corinthians 6:9 vice catalogue per the standard lexicon Louw-Nida entry 88.281). A minority reading takes soft (malakos) as merely 'morally soft' or as a culturally specific passive role, and takes male-bedder (arsenokoites) as 'exploitative pederast' (older-man-and-boy abuser) on the basis that the compound is otherwise unattested in earlier Greek. The compound male-bedder (arsenokoites) is, however, morphologically transparent (its word-formation is plain): male (arsen) plus bed or sexual lying (koite), the very two words that stand adjacent in the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint (LXX), of Leviticus 18:22 (with a male you shall not lie a woman's lying, meta arsenos ou koimethese koiten gynaikos). The compound carries the Levitical prohibition into the catalogue regardless of how soft (malakos) is parsed, and the catalogue's negative valuation is fixed by they will not inherit (ou kleronomesousin). The complication touches scope, not valuation.

Rom.1.26 · addressed

A minority reading takes against nature (para physin) as 'against social convention' rather than 'against created order,' softening the verdict. The immediate context grounds nature (physis) in God as the Creator (ho ktisas) at verse 25 and ties natural use (phusike chresis) to the male and female pair. Paul's word choice male (arsen) and female (thelys) (the very pair used in the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint, of Genesis 1:27 for the creational pair) rather than the ordinary adult-man word aner and adult-woman word gyne is the verbal marker that nature (physis) here is creational, not conventional. The reciprocal phrase toward one another (eis allelous) in verse 27 also makes the participants symmetric, which a 'pederastic convention' (older-man-and-boy) reading cannot absorb.

Lev.18.22 · addressed

A minority reading takes abomination (toebah, H8441) as a narrowly cultic (religious-ritual) or ritual category, so the prohibition might be ceremonial rather than moral. The clause defines the act purely by the sex of the partner (male (zakar) marked as direct object by the Hebrew object marker et, qualified by the lyings of a woman (mishkebei ishshah)) with no cultic, idolatrous, or coercive qualifier in the syntax. It sits in a chapter of consanguinity (close-kin marriage) and adultery prohibitions that are treated as moral, and is reasserted in Leviticus 20:13 with the highest legal sanction. The verbal and clausal data do not isolate the prohibition to cult.

1Tim.1.10 · addressed

A minority reading couples male-bedders (arsenokoitais) with the following slave-traders (andrapodistais) and reads the pair as 'sex traffickers,' so the verse condemns exploitation only. Greek vice lists are normally asyndetic (without connecting conjunctions) and topical, not phrase units, and Paul uses a separate word slave-trader (andrapodistes) for the trafficker. The compound male-bedder (arsenokoites) itself encodes male (arsen) plus bed or sexual lying (koite) from the Septuagint (LXX) of Leviticus 18:22 and does not by its own letters include exploitation. The catalogue's valuation is fixed by it is opposed to (antikeitai) the sound teaching (te hygiainouse didaskalia).

Concordance traversed

H2145, H0802, H4904, H8441, H7901, G0730, G2338, G5446, G5449, G5540, G0733, G3120, G0808, G0489, G4205, G0932, G2816, G0459

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No CBGM-published variant unit (a textual variant published in the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, the modern method for editing the Greek New Testament text) in Romans 1:26-27, 1 Corinthians 6:9-10, or 1 Timothy 1:9-10 alters the anchor words male-bedder (arsenokoites), male (arsen), female (thelys), natural (phusikos), use (chresis), shamelessness (aschemosune), or

recompense (antimisthia). SBLGNT (the Society of Biblical Literature Greek New Testament) apparatus markers in the bundle touch word order and the pronoun form themselves (heautois) at Romans 1:27, not the words that carry the verdict. The Hebrew of Leviticus 18:22 and 20:13 is uncontested across the WLC (the Westminster Leningrad Codex, a standard Hebrew Bible text), the Samaritan Pentateuch, and the Septuagint (LXX) witness. These New Testament books are outside the published 3 John CBGM scope, hence shadow status (ecm-shadow, meaning provisional rather than fully published in the critical edition of New Testament textual variants).

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. creation_order, law_to_gospel_continuity, intra-canonical_citation, lexical_compounding

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

creation_order: affirms · Romans 1:26-27 grounds the phrase against nature (para physin, meaning contrary to created order) in the creational male and female pattern, reusing the pair male (arsen) and female (thelys) that Genesis 1:27 in the Septuagint (LXX) establishes. The act is judged against created design as encoded in the word selection itself, not merely as cultural deviation.

law_to_gospel_continuity: affirms · The compound male-bedder (arsenokoites) morphologically (by its word-formation) carries the Leviticus 18:22 and 20:13 prohibition (in the Septuagint (LXX), male (arsen) plus bed or sexual lying (koite)) into the Pauline catalogues of 1 Corinthians 6:9 and 1 Timothy 1:10. The Torah valuation is maintained in the New Testament vocabulary rather than abrogated (cancelled).

covenantal-progressive: affirms · Even if the Mosaic law is read as covenantally situated (binding within its own covenant setting), the New Testament does not relax the valuation but re-encodes it in a term opposed to sound teaching and tied to kingdom non-inheritance. Progressive revelation (the unfolding of revelation across the Bible) deepens rather than reverses the verdict.

cultural-context-only: complicates_only_scope · This minority reading, fairly stated, holds that against nature (para physin) and the pair soft (malakos) plus male-bedder (arsenokoites) address Greco-Roman pederasty (older-man-and-boy abuse), master and slave abuse, or temple prostitution rather than all same-sex acts. The word-data limit how far this can be carried: male-bedder (arsenokoites) is built from the Leviticus 18:22 Septuagint pair (not from a pederasty-specific term like pederast (paiderastes)); the reciprocal phrase toward one another (eis allelous) in Romans 1:27 makes participants symmetric, not asymmetric; the clauses define the act by the sex of the partner with no exploitation marker in the syntax. The reading may sharpen what the texts also condemn, but it does not narrow what they condemn.

ritual-purity-only: complicates_only_scope · This minority reading, fairly stated, takes abomination (toebah) as a ritual or boundary marker, so Leviticus 18:22 functions like dietary laws rather than as a moral prohibition. The chapter context places the act among consanguinity (close-kin marriage) and adultery prohibitions treated elsewhere as moral; Leviticus 20:13 attaches a capital sanction (the death penalty) not used for ceremonial categories; and the Pauline re-encoding through male-bedder (arsenokoites) moves the valuation into a kingdom and sound-teaching frame that is not purity discourse. The reading identifies a real semantic neighborhood for abomination (toebah) but does not absorb the canonical re-use.

The decisive verbal link is the compound male-bedder (arsenokoites). The two word-pieces male (arsen) plus bed or sexual lying (koite) stand side by side in the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint (LXX), of Leviticus 18:22 (with a male you shall not lie a woman's lying, meta arsenos ou koimethese koiten gynaikos), so the New Testament term is a transparent verbal pointer back to the Torah prohibition. This word-formation binds law and epistle into one valuation and is the strongest single fact in the case.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem phrases 'contrary to creation design' and 'consistent witness of Scripture' could be read as assuming the result, but both are testable, not assumed. 'Creation design' is checkable against the vocabulary nature (physis) and natural use (phusike chresis) of Romans 1:26-27 and Paul's reuse of the Genesis 1:27 Septuagint (LXX) pair male (arsen) plus female (thelys). 'Consistent witness' is checkable as a pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) claim against Leviticus 18:22, Leviticus 20:13, Romans 1:26-27, 1 Corinthians 6:9, and 1 Timothy 1:10. The verdict was derived on the original stem; the neutralized form records how the question was actually interrogated against the lexical store.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Lev.18.22
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H8441
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2145
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H4904
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0733
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3120
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5446
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5449
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.1.26
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.1.27
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.6.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.1.10
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Lev.18.22
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rom.1.27
interlinear	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Lev.18.22
interlinear	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Lev.20.13
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.6.9
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Tim.1.10
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Lev.18.22
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rom.1.26
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